Country Profile: Greece

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 6
- Plurality religion: Greek Orthodox
- Official language: None
- Official religion: Greek Orthodox
- Core group: Greeks

Historical Background

Greece liberated itself from Nazi occupation in October 1944.[1] Following liberation, Greece plunged into a civil war between nationalist forces backed by the West and the Democratic Army of Greece (ELAS), aligned with the Communist Party of Greece.[2] The victory of the pro-Western forces solidified Greece's political and economic alignment with the Western bloc. A military regime lasted from 1967 to 1974, during which civil liberties were suppressed, special military courts were established, and political parties were dissolved.[3] The military regime ended in 1974, and a subsequent referendum abolished the monarchy, restoring democracy. Greece joined the European Community in 1981.[4] Greece's borders remained largely unchanged after World War II, with the only significant adjustment occurring in 1947, when the Treaty of Paris resulted in Italy transferring the Dodecanese islands to Greece.[5]

Groups

- **Greeks** are the core group of the country, comprising approximately 78% of the population.[6] They speak Modern Greek, the de facto national language, and are

[1] Greek City Times, 2022.
[2] Marantzidis and Antoniou, 2004.
[3] Clogg, 2021,
[4] Ibid.
[5] Protothema English, 2017.
[6] AMAR, 2016.

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predominantly adherents of the Greek Orthodox Church, which has historically played a crucial role in shaping and preserving their national identity.[7]

- **Albanians** make up around 4% of Greece's population, with a notable concentration in Epirus and Western Macedonia.[8] The Arvanites, the first Albanian ethnic groups, settled in Greece during the 13th and 14th centuries and have become deeply integrated into Greek culture.[9] Two significant waves of subsequent Albanian immigration occurred: the first from the Balkan Wars (1912–1913) and through the end of World War II, and the second in the 1990s following the collapse of Communism.[10] Albanians in Greece primarily speak Tosk Albanian, with many also fluent in Gheg Albanian.[11] Their religious composition has varied over time. While Eastern Orthodox Albanians were once prominent, the expulsion of Sunni Muslim Chams in 1944–1945 along with the influx of Albanians in the 1990s led to an increase in the number of Sunni Muslims, who now form the dominant religious group among Albanians in Greece.[12]
- **Aromanians, also known as Vlachs**, comprise about 6% of Greece's population and primarily reside in the northern regions, including the Pindus Mountains, Meglen, around Lake Prespa, and the mountains of Olympus and Vermion.[13] In Greece, there are two Vlach languages: Megleno-Romanian, spoken by a group identifying as Vlasi, and Aromanian, spoken by those calling themselves Armin.[14] Aromanian is considered moribund and has largely disappeared from education since the last Romanian school in Greece closed in 1948.[15] The majority of Aromanians (Vlachs) adhere to the Greek Orthodox faith.[16]
- **Thracian Muslims**, a nested group of the Muslim population, have historically resided in the region of Western Thrace and make up about 1.3% of the population.[17] The subgroups considered are **Turks**, **Pomaks** (Muslim Bulgarians),

[7] Ethnologue, 2024; Koumandaraki, 2002.
[8] AMAR, 2016; Joshua Project, 2024.
[9] Lyberaki and Maroukis, 2005.
[10] Adamczyk, 2016.
[11] Ethnologue, 2024; Joshua Project, 2024.
[12] Manta, 2009; Grigoropoulou and Chryssochoou, 2011; Gemi, 2019.
[13] AMAR, 2016; Minority Rights, 2018e.
[14] Minority rights, 2018e.
[15] Ethnologue, 2024; Council of Europe, 1997.
[16] Council of Europe, 1997.
[17] Joshua Project, 2024; Borou, 2009.

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and **Muslim Roma**.[18] These groups are linked by their adherence to Sunni Islam and share a regional identity, despite speaking different languages. Turks speak Turkish; Pomaks have Bulgarian as their ancestral language but are also fluent in Turkish; and most Muslim Roma speak Vlax Romani.[19] These groups were historically racialized based on their ethno-national membership within the millet system of the Ottoman Empire. Today, only Roma are considered a racial group.[20]

- **Roma** established their presence in Greece in the 11th century and currently make up around 1.8% of the population.[21] They speak different variants of the Romani macrolanguage, including Balkan Romani and Vlax Romani.[22] Due to their long history of assimilation into Greek culture, most Roma are adherents of the Greek Orthodox Church.[23] Historically, the Roma community in Greece has faced significant stigmatization, which has contributed to their marginalization and racialization.[24] This, in turn, has led to a persistent low socioeconomic status, which continues to mark their distinct identity within the country.[25]
- **Macedonians** make up around 1.4% of Greece's population and are primarily concentrated in Northern Greece, a region that became part of the country following the Balkan Wars.[26] The name of this area, which is referred to as Macedonia in Greek, has been a source of dispute with the former Yugoslav Republic of Macedonia (FYROM).[27] The Macedonian minority in Northern Greece has renewed calls for official minority status, but these efforts have not evolved into a self-determination movement. Macedonian is their ancestral language, and they have adhered to the Macedonian Orthodox Church since its declaration of autocephaly in 1967. Additionally, a portion of Macedonians are Sunni Muslims.[28]

[18] Minority Rights, 2018d.
[19] Ethnologue, 2024; Minority Rights, 2018d.
[20] Hatziprokopiou and Evergeti, 2014.
[21] Minority Rights, 2018c; AMAR, 2016.
[22] Ethnologue, 2024.
[23] Joshua Project, 2024.
[24] Zachos, 2012.
[25] European Commission Against Racism and Intolerance, 2015.
[26] Minority Rights, 2018b.
[27] Ibid.
[28] Joshua Project, 2024.

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State Profile

Official Language

Greek is the *de facto* official language of the state during the entire period, despite only being formally recognized as such from 1952 to 1975. This was indicated in Article 107 of the 1952 Constitution, which declared that "the official language of the State is that in which the Constitution and the laws of Greece are drawn up [Greek], and any attempt to corrupt it is prohibited." The same provisions are repeated in the 1968 Constitution.

Official Religion

Greek Orthodox Christianity is officially acknowledged as the state religion in all constitutions. The Greek Orthodox Church is described either as the country's established, dominant, or prevailing religion. The constitutional provisions acknowledge that the Greek Orthodox Church and the Great Church of Constantinople are "inseparably united."[29]

Education Policies

In Greece, compulsory education spans 11 years, covering ages 4 to 15, and includes primary and lower secondary education.[30] Primary education consists of pre-school and primary school for children aged 4 to 12, while secondary education is divided into two cycles: *gymnasio* (lower secondary school), which is compulsory and lasts three years for students aged 12 to 15, and *lykeio* (upper secondary school), which is optional and lasts another three years for students aged 15 to 18.[31] The Greek educational system is governed by national laws and regulations set by the Ministry of Education, Religious Affairs and Sports.[32]

There is **no legally mandated segregation** in education. However, there are two distinct public education systems: the Greek system and the Greek-Turkish bilingual system, which exists only in Western Thrace due to the 1923 Lausanne Treaty.[33] While the Turkish minority has access to bilingual schools, they are not legally required to attend them. Families can choose between semi-private bilingual minority schools and public

[29] Constitution of Greece, 1975; Constitution of Greece, 1952; Constitution of Greece, 1968; Constitution of Greece, 1927.

[30] Eurydice, 2024.

[31] Ibid.

[32] Ibid.

[33] Theodoropoulou and Dendrinos, 2009.

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monolingual Greek schools for primary education, and students can continue their education in either bilingual or public Greek secondary schools.[34] Since minority schools are regarded as private institutions regulated by public school legislation, **private schools** in Greece typically function without limitations on the language of instruction.[35]

Greek public education follows a largely monoethnic policy, refusing to acknowledge the existence of other ethnicities. Muslims are one prominent exception. Since 1996, the government has supported an **affirmative action** policy providing a 0.5% quota for Muslim minority members' access to higher education.[36]

Language Education Policies

The Greek education system is governed by several constitutional and legislative frameworks that do not explicitly mandate a language of instruction, implicitly confirming **Modern Greek** (Demotic) as the de facto language. The 1985 Law on the Structure and Operation of Primary and Secondary Education further entrenched Greek as the official language, stating that "the language of instruction [...] must be the demotic [Greek] language."[37]

Minority languages such as **Tosk Albanian, Gheg Albanian, Aromanian, Megleno-Romanian,** and **Macedonian** are not officially recognized by Greek law and are not used as instructional languages in public schools. The 1996 initiative to establish intercultural schools, which was intended to incorporate minority languages and cultures into the curriculum, has focused more on Greek language instruction rather than teaching minority languages.[38]

Turkish is the only minority language officially recognized in Greece, as mandated by the 1923 Lausanne Treaty.[39] This has resulted in the establishment of Greek-Turkish bilingual schools in Western Thrace, governed by a combination of regulations that apply to both private and public institutions. The 1977 Law No. 694 on the Minority Schools of the Muslim Community in Western Thrace specifically addressed the Turkish language, ensuring its use in minority education.[40] Other languages of the Thracian Muslim minority,

[34] Mercator, 2019.
[35] Tsitselikis, 2004.
[36] Liagkis and Ziaka, 2015.
[37] L'Aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2024.
[38] Ibid.
[39] Ibid.
[40] Tsitselikis, 2004.

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such as the **Bulgarian** and **Romani** languages (Balkan and Vlax), are not provided with educational opportunities in their native tongues within the public education system.[41]

Religious Education Policies

Religious education has been a consistent part of Greek public schools since the end of World War II.[42] The 1985 Law on Education mandates that all students receive instruction in the Orthodox tradition as a core component of their education. While students who are not Greek Orthodox have the right to opt out of these classes, there have been no alternative classes focused on other religions available to them.[43]

The law provides for the possibility of offering confessional religious education to other religious communities, contingent on a minimum of five students requesting it.[44] However, this provision has seen limited application. The Catholic community, for instance, successfully acquired religious education in 2013, but other groups, such as Muslims in Athens, have lobbied unsuccessfully for Islamic education.[45] Recent reforms, including the "New School" framework and 2016 guidelines, aim to broaden religious education to include other religions, but the new curriculum still predominantly reflects a monocultural approach.[46]

Bans and Restrictions

There are no official bans or restrictions on the use of minority languages. Greece has historically been a monolingual country, with Greek as the de facto national language since its establishment in 1824. Other languages are not actively supported or promoted, except for Turkish, which is protected under the 1923 Lausanne Treaty. The Macedonian language, in particular, is not officially recognized by the Greek state, and there are no legal provisions supporting its use in public life or education. The Greek government has not implemented any policies to favor or regulate the use of Macedonian, and there are no media outlets in Macedonian within Greece, apart from those transmitted from Northern Macedonia.[47] While there is no explicit prohibition on the use of Macedonian

[41] Dimasi, Krimpas. 2016.
[42] Perselis, 1984.
[43] Liagkis, 2015.
[44] Ibid.
[45] US Department of State, 2008.
[46] US Department of State, 2016.
[47] Schmieger, 1998.

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names for places and people, the authorities have historically renamed places with Greek names, and religious authorities have encouraged Greek naming practices.[48]

Bans on conversion and proselytizing: The Greek Orthodox Church has been established as the state religion in the constitutions of Greece. While the earlier constitutions prohibited proselytism only if it was against the Greek Orthodox Church, the 1975 Constitution extended this ban to all religions.[49]

Demographic Engineering and Violence

Forced Relocations

Albanians: Historical records and studies document two significant expulsions of Albanians from Greece: the first in 1944–1945, targeting 18,000 Cham Albanians, and the second in 1993–1994, affecting between 96,000 and 100,000 recent Albanian immigrants.[50] The 1944–1945 expulsion, marked by paramilitary violence, forced Muslim Cham Albanians to flee to Albania.[51] The stricter immigration controls introduced by the 1991 Law 1975/1991 and the 1992 Interministerial Decree led to the expulsion of hundreds of thousands of Albanians.[52] However, Albanians of "Greek nationality" and those of "Greek Orthodox religion" were exempt from these expulsions.[53]

Cultural Elimination

Macedonians: While outright bans on the Macedonian language began under the Metaxas regime in the 1930s, the postwar period saw continued enforcement through education, policing, and administrative controls.

Following the Varkiza Agreement in February 1945, the Greek government reimposed a blanket ban on the public use of the Macedonian language—a prohibition enforced through police harassment, closures of Slavic-language presses, and criminal penalties for speakers.[54] These language restrictions persisted throughout the Greek Civil War (1946–1949), during which Macedonian-speaking communities were accused of

[48] Carabott, 2005.
[49] Constitution of Greece, 1975; Constitution of Greece, 1952; Constitution of Greece, 1968; Constitution of Greece, 1927.
[50] Garrity, 2022.
[51] Dervishi, 2019.
[52] Baldwin-Edwards, 2004.
[53] Adamczyk, 2016.
[54] Stefov, 2016.

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communist sympathies and their schools and cultural associations shuttered. After the war, successive governments maintained the ban, officially prohibiting Macedonian in education, broadcasting, and public gatherings, until the collapse of the military junta in 1974, after which Greece's gradual return to parliamentary democracy and accession to the Council of Europe led to a modest liberalization of minority-language rights by the late 1970s.

Constitutions and Laws

The provisions regarding minorities, religion, and linguistic rights have remained largely consistent in the constitutions of Greece. The 1927 Constitution, reinstated in 1944 after the Nazi occupation, declared Greece a democratic republic and referred to its people as "Hellenic citizens."[55] This 1927 Constitution recognizes the Eastern Orthodox Church of Christ as the "predominant" religion, and freedom of religion is guaranteed.[56]

Following the Greek Civil War, the 1952 Constitution was adopted which officially designated the state language in Article 108.[57] When the military junta seized power in 1967, they introduced the 1968 Constitution. This constitution restricted civil rights but retained similar linguistic and religious provisions as the 1952 Constitution.[58]

In 1974, after the fall of the junta, the 1952 Constitution was reinstated and the monarchy was abolished following the referendums of 1973–1974.[59] In 1975, Greece adopted its current constitution, establishing the nation as a parliamentary republic, elaborating on the status of the Greek Orthodox Church as the state religion, and frequently referring to "Hellenes," "Greek people," and "Greeks."[60] The 1975 Constitution guarantees freedom of conscience but does not specify an official state language.[61]

Citizenship Laws

Greek citizenship has long been based on the principle of *jus sanguinis*, as outlined in the 1856 Civil Law and the 1955 Code on Greek Nationality, and reinforced by Law 1438/1984

[55] Constitution of Greece, 1927.
[56] Ibid.
[57] Constitution of Greece, 1952; Nohlen and Stöver, 2010.
[58] Constitution of Greece, 1968.
[59] Roberts, 1974.
[60] Constitution of Greece, 1975.
[61] Ibid.

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and the 2004 Code on Greek Nationality.[62] The 1984 amendment expanded citizenship acquisition to come from either parent. Historically, these laws did not exclude any minority groups, allowing non-Greeks in the Dodecanese to gain citizenship after the territory's annexation in 1947.[63] The *jus soli* principle in Greece is limited, mainly applying to stateless individuals or those born to unknown parents. However, a 2010 reform introduced conditional birthright citizenship for children of immigrants born in Greece, provided both parents have legally resided in the country for at least five years.[64]

Since the end of the Cold War, Greece has experienced demographic shifts, particularly with the influx of Pontic Greeks.[65] In 2000, the government eased the naturalization process for this group. Additionally, EU citizens can benefit from an easier naturalization process, requiring only three years of lawful residence, notably affecting Bulgarians and Romanians.[66]

National Anthem(s)

The national anthem of Greece, adopted in 1864, is based on the "Hymn to Freedom," a lengthy 158-verse poem. The anthem evokes powerful imagery related to the nation's identity and history. It includes references to national territory, as seen in the line, "I recognize you by your face that violently defines the land," symbolizing the borders of the homeland. Military prowess is highlighted with the phrase, "I recognize you by the fearsome sharpness of your sword," emphasizing the strength and valor of the Greek people. Additionally, the anthem celebrates Greek nationhood, particularly through the line, "From the sacred bones, of the Hellenes arisen, and valiant again as you once were."[67]

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[64] Ibid.
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[66] Ibid.
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